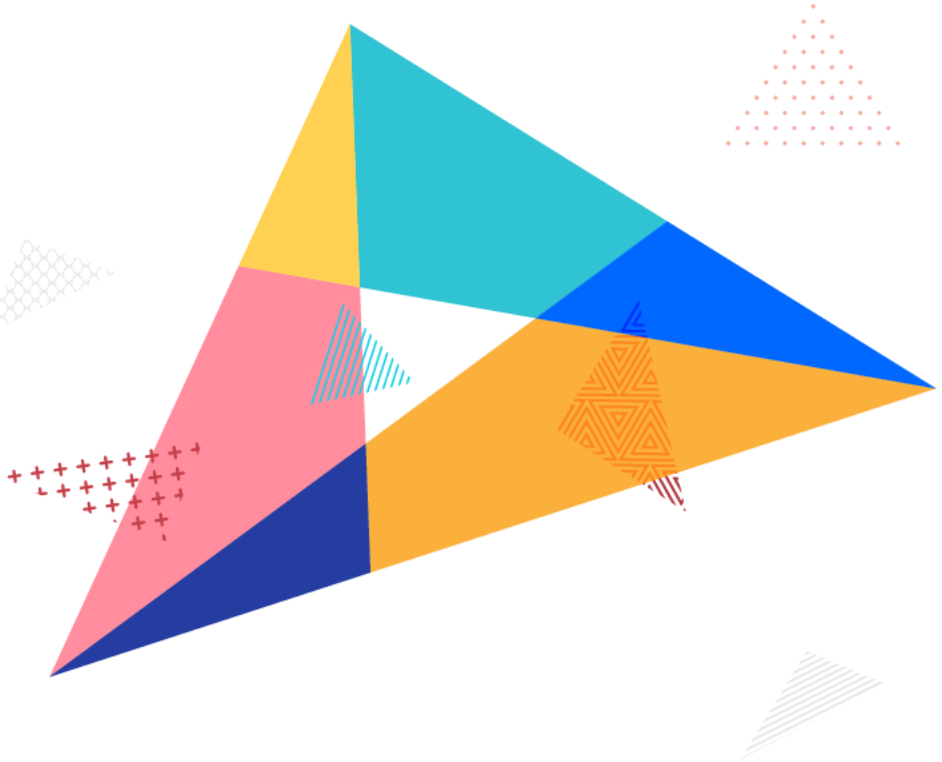
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Stakeholder Influence & Leadership in Technology

Core question:

How do I build the relationships, trust and influence needed to move complex technology agendas forward?

Prof. Seng Kiat Kok

DAY AT A GLANCE

One Day. Seven Focus Areas

MORNING

Understand the Landscape, Build Credibility

1. Read the Stakeholder Landscape
2. Build Trust & Leadership Credibility
3. Influence Without Authority

AFTERNOON

Influence, Alignment and Action

4. Understand the Sources of Power
5. Influence Without Authority (Exchange)
6. Conflict → Alignment
7. Leading Change Through Coalitions

By the End of the Day, You Can Say:

1

"I know my stakeholder landscape."

I understand who has influence, what they care about and where the risks are.

2

"I know how to influence them."

I can adapt my approach based on trust, power, motivation and the nature of the relationship.

3

"I know what I will do next."

I have a practical 90-day stakeholder strategy linked to a real technology initiative.

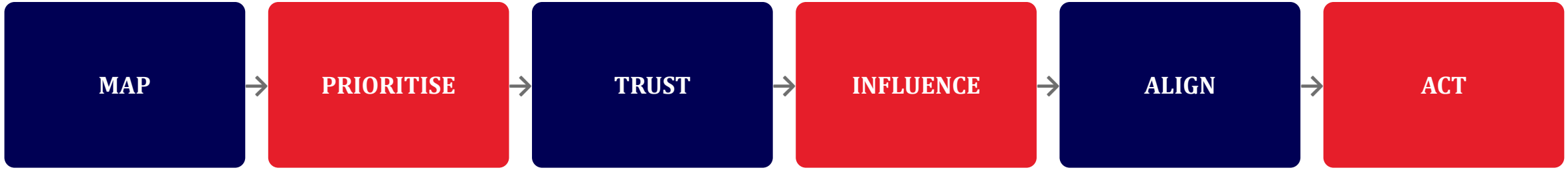
CORE QUESTION

How do I build the relationships, trust and influence needed to move complex technology agendas forward?

Technology initiatives succeed or stall based on relationships, not just roadmaps. Today is about building the influence skillset that moves your agenda forward.

THE DAY IN ONE FRAMEWORK

MAP → PRIORITISE → TRUST → INFLUENCE → ALIGN → ACT



Each stage is anchored to a core theory and a practical tool you will use today — building toward a real, actionable stakeholder strategy for your own initiative.

MORNING

AM Understand the Landscape, Build Credibility

Before you can influence anyone, you need to know who matters, why they matter, and whether they trust you. The morning builds that foundation.

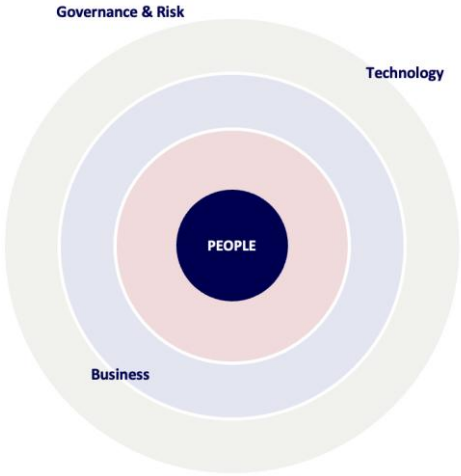
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THEORY 1 · FREEMAN (1984)

Stakeholder Theory

WHAT IS THE THEORY?

Organisations should be understood through the relationships they have with multiple stakeholder groups — not simply through shareholders, hierarchy or internal structures. A stakeholder is anyone who can affect, or is affected by, the organisation or initiative.



EXECUTIVE VALUE — SHIFT THE QUESTION

From "Who reports to me?" to "Who can affect the outcome, and whose interests are affected by it?"

TECHNOLOGY APPLICATION

Particularly useful for AI adoption, ERP transformation, cybersecurity, data governance and digital transformation, where multiple stakeholder groups can influence success.

PROS	CONS / LIMITATIONS
Broadens thinking beyond formal organisational structures	Can create a very large stakeholder population
Highlights competing interests and dependencies	Does not automatically tell leaders which stakeholder matters most
Useful for complex transformation environments	Stakeholder interests can conflict
Encourages consideration of external stakeholders	Can lead to excessive consultation
Strong foundation for stakeholder mapping	Requires judgement about whose interests should take priority

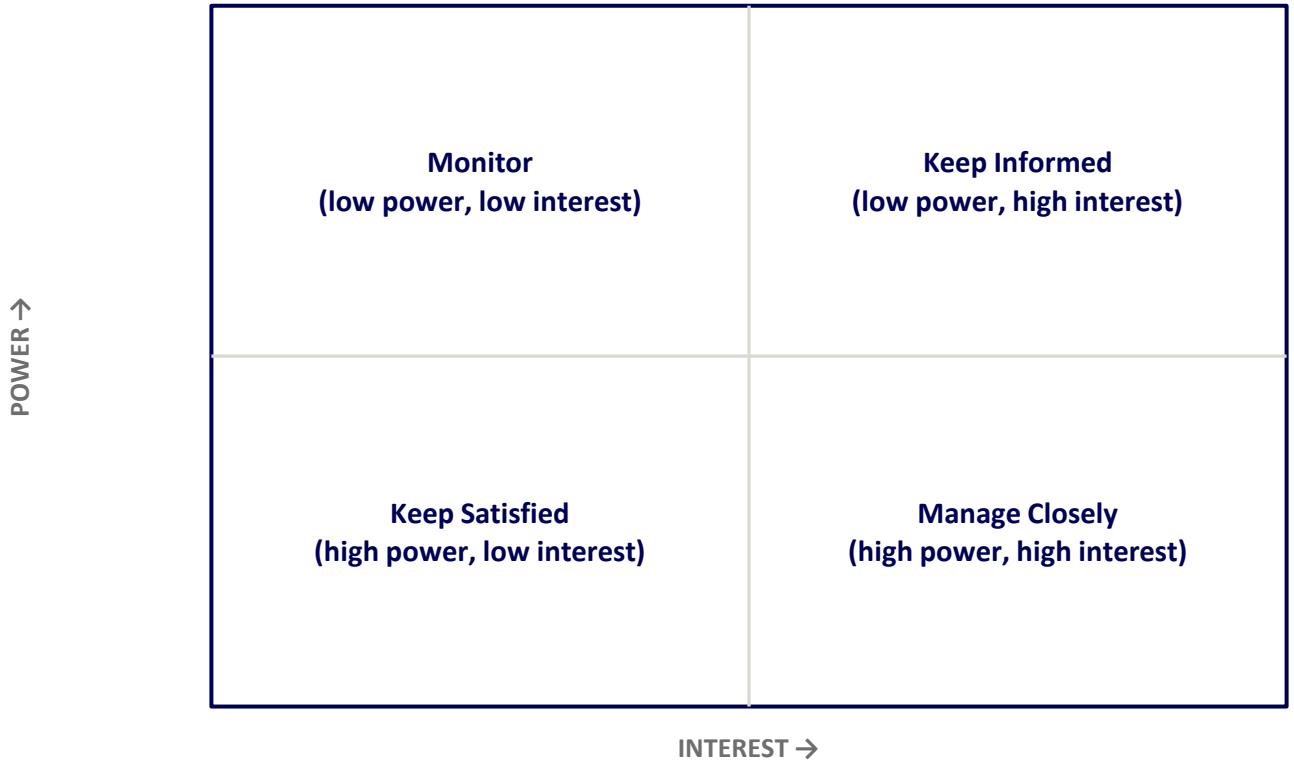
★ TAKEAWAY ***Map the system before trying to influence the system.***

Freeman, R. E. (1984). Strategic Management: A Stakeholder Approach. Pitman.

THEORY 2 · MENDELOW (1991)

The Power–Interest Matrix

THEORY · Mendelow (1991) — plot stakeholders by the power they hold and the interest they take, to decide where your attention should go.



Technology initiatives sit at the intersection of business, technology, governance, risk and people. As leaders you need **to learn to move beyond the org chart and identify who really matters.**

EXECUTIVE VALUE

"Where should I spend my limited relationship and communication capacity?"

TECHNOLOGY APPLICATION

Identifying who needs intensive engagement during major investments, transformation programs, technology migrations and organisational change.

TAKEAWAY ***Not every stakeholder needs equal attention - but the right stakeholders need the right attention***

Tasks to Mapping Stakeholders

1 Stakeholder Ecosystem Map

Visualise everyone with a stake — business, technology, governance, risk, people — beyond the formal org chart.

2 Power–Interest Matrix

Plot each stakeholder to decide who to manage closely, keep satisfied, keep informed, or simply monitor.

Activity

ACTIVITY

1. Individually, list every stakeholder connected to your technology initiative — aim for at least 10, going beyond your direct reporting line.
2. Plot each one on the Power–Interest Matrix on your worksheet.
3. Circle any name/group you placed with hesitation — that hesitation is often the signal of an underestimated stakeholder.
4. Share with the class why you have indicated them as a stakeholder.

Debrief: Who showed up in your blind spot, and why didn't you consider them important?

MORNING · SESSION 1

Know Who Matters

EXECUTIVE TAKEAWAY

Know who matters, why they matter, and where your attention should go.

COACHING QUESTION

Who can influence the success of my initiative that I am currently underestimating?

THEORY 3 · KOUZES & POSNER (2023)

The Leadership Challenge

WHAT IS THE THEORY?

Identifies five practices associated with effective leadership. The underlying premise: leadership is demonstrated through observable behaviours, not simply position or authority.

TECHNOLOGY APPLICATION

Technology leaders need to establish credibility while asking people to adopt new systems, AI, new ways of working and unfamiliar technologies.

1. MODEL THE WAY
2. INSPIRE SHARED VISION
3. CHALLENGE THE PROCESS
4. ENABLE OTHERS TO ACT
5. ENCOURAGE THE HEART

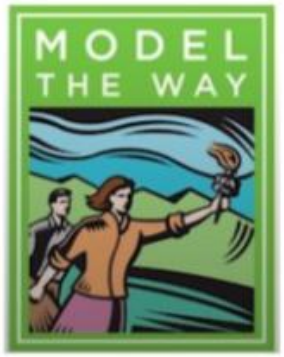
PROS	CONS / LIMITATIONS
Behaviour-focused and accessible	Can appear broad rather than highly diagnostic
Strong emphasis on credibility and role modelling	Does not provide a detailed stakeholder prioritisation method
Encourages shared leadership and collaboration	Leadership behaviours may need cultural adaptation
Highly relevant to change and innovation	Can feel aspirational without practice and feedback
Easy to translate into personal leadership actions	Does not by itself resolve organisational power dynamics

★ TAKEAWAY ***Your influence is shaped by how people experience your leadership — not just by your title.***

Kouzes, J. M., & Posner, B. Z. (2023). The Leadership Challenge: How to Make Extraordinary Things Happen in Organizations (7th ed.). Wiley.

Build Trust and Leadership Credibility

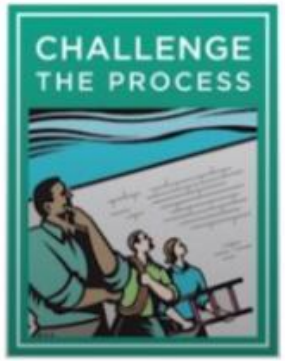
Influence starts with credibility and relationships. Explore how leaders create trust, invite challenge, and build environments where people can speak honestly about risk, problems and competing perspectives.



Model the way: they act as a role model, and set other people up for success



Inspire a shared vision: they communicate their vision and persuade others to commit to it



Challenge the process: they take risks and learn from mistakes and successes



Enable others to act: they foster collaboration and get people to work together, thereby strengthening others



Encourage the heart: they reward individual contributions, and celebrate group accomplishments

Source: Kouzes, J and Posner, B 2012 'The Leadership Challenge' 6th Jossey-Bass, San Francisco, Chapter one

CASE STUDY · TECH INDUSTRY

Microsoft: Rebuilding Trust from the Top



The situation: When Satya Nadella became CEO in 2014, Microsoft's culture was widely described as siloed and internally competitive, with business units guarding turf rather than collaborating on shared technology bets.

1

Model the way

Nadella publicly championed a "growth mindset", explicitly naming learning over knowing-it-all as the leadership standard he wanted modelled at every level.

2

Build psychological safety

Leaders were encouraged to say "I don't know" and treat failed bets as data, lowering the cost of surfacing bad news about struggling products early.

3

Convert trust into influence

That credibility let Nadella redirect the company toward cloud and cross-platform bets (like Office on iOS) that internal factions had previously resisted.

Discussion: Where in your organisation would naming "what I don't know" build more credibility than pretending to have the answer?

Tasks to Mapping Stakeholders

1 Stakeholder Ecosystem Map

Visualise everyone with a stake — business, technology, governance, risk, people — beyond the formal org chart.

2 Power–Interest Matrix

Plot each stakeholder to decide who to manage closely, keep satisfied, keep informed, or simply monitor.

3 Influencing

Who and where do we influence stakeholders to get traction



What is Influence?

- *the capacity or power of persons/things to be a compelling force on, or produce effects on, the actions, behaviour or opinions of others”*

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MORNING · SESSION 3

Influence Without Authority

Bringing the morning together: participants identify where they most need to influence people they cannot simply direct.

Upwards

Influencing sponsors, boards and senior leaders who control resourcing and priority.

Across Functions

Aligning peers in finance, operations, legal and other business units.

Across Technical / Business Boundaries

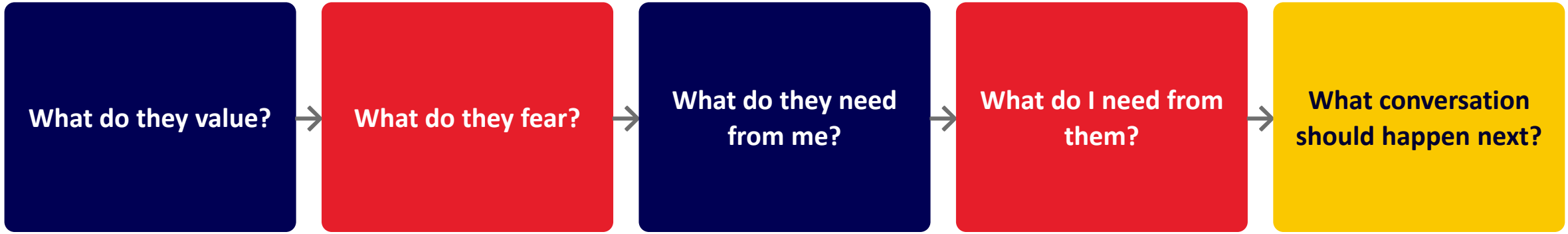
Translating technical trade-offs into business language, and back again.

Through Informal Networks

Mobilising trusted connectors who shape opinion outside the formal hierarchy.

Practical Tool: Executive Influence Map

For each priority stakeholder, work through this chain of questions:



This chain moves you from empathy (their values and fears) to reciprocity (mutual need) to concrete action (the next conversation) — the backbone of influence without authority.

MORNING · SESSION 3

Activity: Build Your Executive Influence Map

INTERACTIVE ACTIVITY

1. From your Power–Interest Matrix, select your three highest-priority stakeholders.
2. Complete the five-question Influence Map chain for each one in your groups
3. Write down the one conversation you will have first, and by when.

Debrief: Which of your three planned conversations feels most uncomfortable — and what does that tell you?

MORNING OUTPUT

Each Group Leaves the Morning With:

1 A prioritised stakeholder map

Plotted on the Power–Interest Matrix, grounded in a real initiative.

2 Three priority relationships

Identified through the Executive Influence Map, with a next conversation planned.



BREAK

The afternoon shifts from understanding to action: power, exchange, conflict and coalition-building.

AFTERNOON

PM

Influence, Alignment and Action

With a clear map and growing credibility, the afternoon turns to the mechanics of influence, conflict and mobilising others around change.

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What is Power?

- *The potential to influence behaviour, to change the course of events, to overcome resistance, and to get things done through others*
- *Power is in itself neutral - the way it is enacted determines whether the outcomes are positive or negative*
- *The term is often associated with deception, brute force, office politics*

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THEORY 4 · FRENCH & RAVEN (1959)

Sources of Social Power

WHAT IS THE THEORY?

Social power comes from different bases — not simply from formal authority. Informational power was later added as an additional basis.

TECHNOLOGY APPLICATION

A cybersecurity specialist, enterprise architect or highly trusted product leader may have significant expert or referent power even without a senior executive title.

PROS	CONS / LIMITATIONS
Demonstrates that influence is broader than hierarchy	Some categories overlap in practice
Particularly useful for leaders without direct authority	Can encourage a transactional view of influence
Helps identify hidden sources of influence	Does not fully explain how power changes over time
Useful for analysing organisational politics	Ethical use of power requires additional consideration
Easy to apply to stakeholder analysis	Formal and informal power can be difficult to distinguish

★ TAKEAWAY ***Ask not only "What authority do I have?" but "What sources of influence do I have?"***

French, J. R. P., & Raven, B. (1959). The Bases of Social Power. In D. Cartwright (Ed.), Studies in Social Power (pp. 150–167). University of Michigan Press.

AFTERNOON · SESSION 4

Understand the Sources of Power

THEORY · French & Raven (1959) — power is more than hierarchy.

Legitimate

Leader has authority from formal role or title.

Reward

Leader controls important resources and is able to reward followers

Coercive

Leader uses threat of punishment over followers to coerce obedience

Expert

Leader derives power from their expertise, which followers defer to

Referent

Leader derives power from the desire of followers who have strong feelings of affection, admiration and loyalty

Informational

Leader controls vital information which followers is used to influence followers perceptions and attitudes

AFTERNOON · SESSION 4

Power Beyond the Org Chart

Technology leadership application: A senior architect, cybersecurity specialist or respected product leader may have enormous influence despite having limited formal authority — driven by expert, referent and informational power rather than title.

PRACTICAL TOOL · Power Audit — for each stakeholder, ask:

1. What power do they have?
2. What power do I have?
3. What power could I build?

AFTERNOON · SESSION 4

Run a Power Audit

INTERACTIVE ACTIVITY

1. Choose one/two stakeholders from your map where you currently feel under-powered.
2. In your groups, work through the Power Audit for that stakeholder: their power, your power, and power you could build.
3. Identify one source of power (expert, referent or informational) you are under-using today.
4. Commit to one specific action this quarter that builds that source of power.

Debrief: Where have you been over-relying on legitimate (title-based) power when another source would work better?

AFTERNOON · SESSION 4

See the Whole Power System

EXECUTIVE TAKEAWAY

Influence increases when you understand the power available in the system — not just the authority in your job title.

COACHING QUESTION

Which source of power am I under-using with my most important stakeholders?

AFTERNOON · SESSION 5

Influence Without Authority: The Exchange

THEORY · Cohen & Bradford (2017) — focus on the exchange behind effective influence.

RATHER THAN ASKING

"How do I get them to support my proposal?"

→

ASK INSTEAD

"What matters to them, and how can we create value for each other?"

Practical Tool: Influence Conversation Planner

1. What matters to them?
2. What matters to me?
3. Where is the mutual value?
4. What can I offer?
5. What do I need?
6. What is the next commitment?

AFTERNOON · SESSION 5

Plan and Rehearse an Exchange

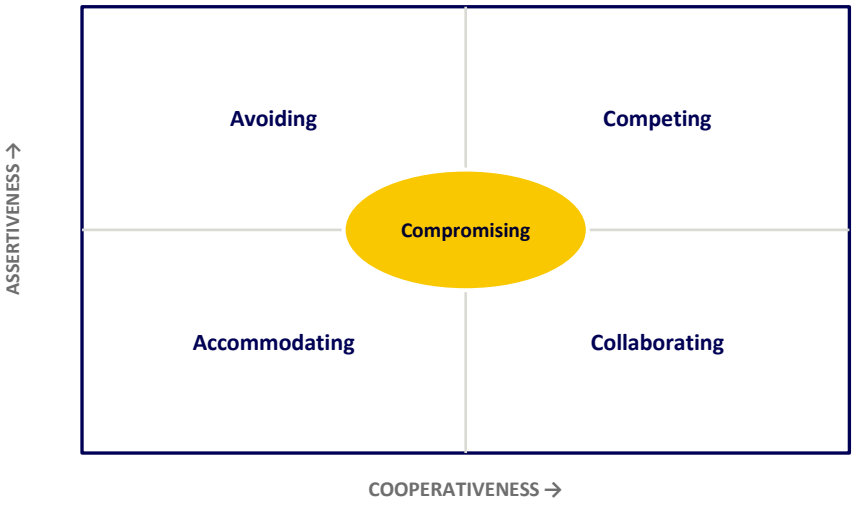
INTERACTIVE ACTIVITY

1. Using the scenarios given, select a key stakeholder and complete the Influence Conversation Planner
2. Create a pitch that will help you successfully influence the stakeholder for change
3. Pitch this to the class

Thomas–Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument

WHAT IS THE THEORY?

Describes five ways people respond to conflict based on two dimensions — assertiveness (pursuing your own concerns) and cooperativeness (satisfying the other person's concerns). No mode is always best; different situations call for different responses.



TECHNOLOGY APPLICATION

Balancing competing priorities: security vs speed · innovation vs risk · centralisation vs autonomy · budget vs capability · deadlines vs quality

PROS	CONS / LIMITATIONS
Simple language for discussing conflict	Can oversimplify complex conflicts
Encourages behavioural flexibility	People may over-identify with a preferred style
Useful for self-awareness	Does not by itself resolve the underlying issue
Helps leaders consider situational responses	Context, culture and power may alter the situation
Practical for coaching and difficult conversations	Conflict can involve more than interpersonal style

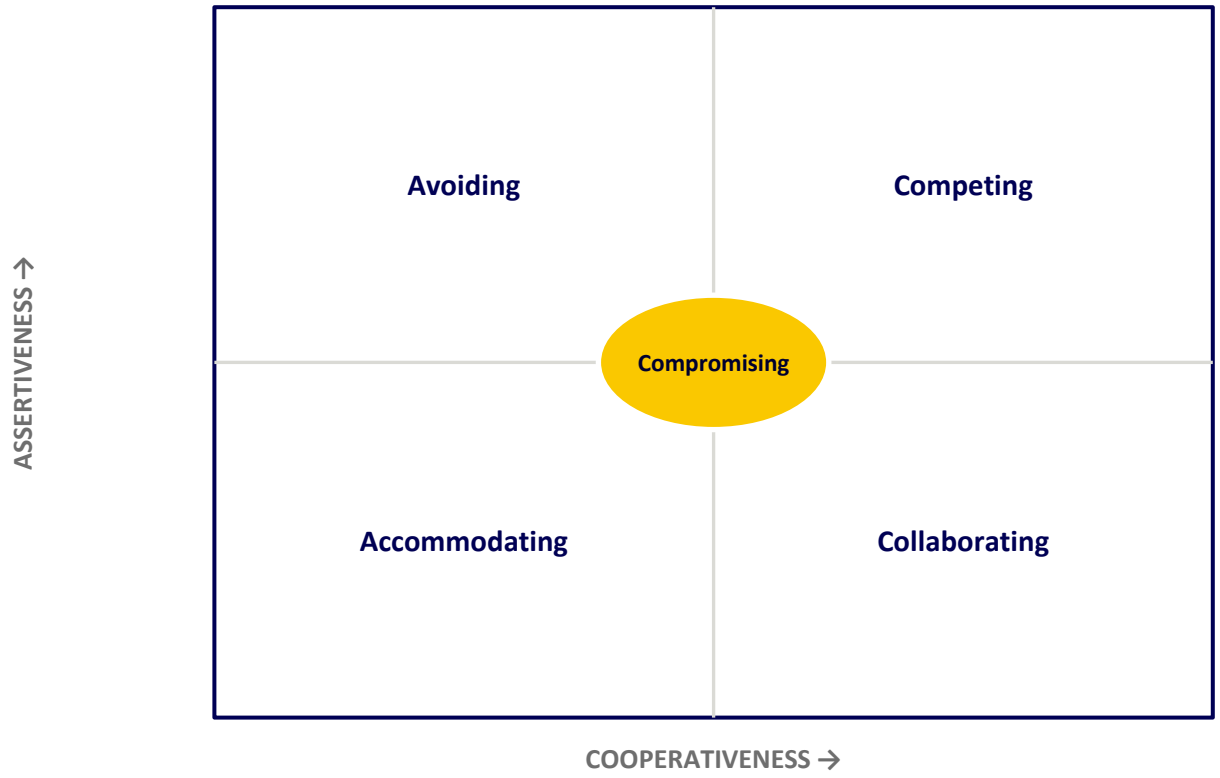
★ **TAKEAWAY** ***The goal is not to avoid conflict — it is to choose the response that best serves the outcome.***

Thomas, K. W., & Kilmann, R. H. (1974/2008). Thomas–Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument. CPP, Inc.

AFTERNOON · SESSION 6

Conflict → Alignment

THEORY · Thomas–Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument — no single "best" style; the question is what the situation requires.



Facilitation note: walk the room through all five modes, then ask which mode participants default to under pressure — and where that default has cost them.

Practical Tool: Conflict Response Planner

Before a difficult conversation, work through:

1. **What is the real issue?**
2. **What is negotiable?**
3. **What is non-negotiable?**
4. **What does the other party need?**
5. **What outcome protects the organisational goal?**
6. **Which conflict mode is appropriate?**

Leading Change Through Stakeholder Coalitions

WHAT IS THE THEORY?

Major organisational change requires leaders to mobilise people, create momentum and build support — rather than simply announce a new direction. For stakeholder leadership, the most important idea is building a credible coalition with enough influence to move the organisation.

TECHNOLOGY APPLICATION — BUILD A COALITION ACROSS

Executive Leadership + Business + Technology + Finance + Risk + People + Users

PROS	CONS / LIMITATIONS
Provides a structured approach to large-scale change	Eight steps can feel linear
Strong emphasis on leadership mobilisation	Real change is often iterative rather than sequential
Highlights coalition-building	May require adaptation to different organisational cultures
Emphasises momentum and visible wins	Can underplay emergent or bottom-up change
Highly applicable to transformation programs	Change rarely follows a perfectly predictable pathway

★ TAKEAWAY ***Don't carry the transformation yourself. Build a coalition that can carry it with you.***

Kotter, J. P. (2012). Leading Change. Harvard Business Review Press.

AFTERNOON · SESSION 7

Leading Change Through Stakeholder Coalitions

THEORY · Kotter (2012) — used selectively, not the full eight-step model. A transformation is rarely driven by the project team alone; it is driven by a coalition of influential stakeholders.



Connect directly to stakeholder influence: your guiding coalition is built from the relationships, trust and power sources you have mapped all day.

AFTERNOON · SESSION 7

Practical Tool: Stakeholder Coalition Map



THE KEY QUESTION

How do I move the undecided toward support?

Champions and influencers rarely need convincing — your leverage is in giving the undecided a low-risk way to say yes, using the trust and power you have already built today.

AFTERNOON · SESSION 7

25 MIN · SMALL GROUPS

Map Your Coalition, Move the Undecided

INTERACTIVE ACTIVITY

1. Sort your key stakeholders into Champions, Influencers, Decision Makers, Blockers and Undecided for your real initiative.
2. In your groups, discuss who sits in your Undecided column and why you believe they haven't committed.
3. Brainstorm as a group: what low-risk "yes" could move each undecided stakeholder toward support?
4. Select one Undecided stakeholder and draft the opening line of the conversation that would move them.

Debrief: Which Blocker is actually an Undecided stakeholder you have mis-categorised?

RECAP

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BRINGING IT TOGETHER

The Day in One Framework

Stage	Core Question	Main Theory	Practical Tool
MAP	Who matters?	Freeman	Stakeholder Ecosystem
PRIORITISE	Where should I focus?	Mendelow	Power–Interest Matrix
TRUST	How do I build credibility?	Kouzes & Posner / Edmondson	Trust & Safety Check
INFLUENCE	How do I move people?	French & Raven / Cohen & Bradford	Influence Planner
ALIGN	How do I manage disagreement?	Thomas–Kilmann	Conflict Planner
ACT	How do I mobilise change?	Kotter	Coalition

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

At the End of the Day, You Can Say:

1

"I know my stakeholder landscape."

I understand who has influence, what they care about and where the risks are.

2

"I know how to influence them."

I can adapt my approach based on trust, power, motivation and the nature of the relationship.

3

"I know what I will do next."

I have a practical 90-day stakeholder strategy linked to a real technology initiative.

APPENDIX

Reference List

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